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Old gods, new rivals and America's uneasy romance with football

World Cup 2026 opens at the Azteca as Messi, Ronaldo, Haaland and Mbappe shape **new rivalries** in an expanded 48-team global spectacle.

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History provides its neat symmetries. The FIFA World Cup 2026 will have a chapter of its own when Mexico takes on South Africa in the opening match of the tournament at the iconic Azteca Stadium. The fixture, along with 71 more clashes, was marked in stone

when the World Cup's die was cast in Washington earlier in December.

The opening clash will be a repeat of the 2010 opener, and Azteca's legacy — it has seen Pele and Diego Maradona lift the World Cup — only adds to the magnificence of the biggest-ever iteration of the quadrennial tournament.

FIFA's expansion to 48 teams from

32 has unfurled its tapestry across hemispheres, weaving new, distant threads into its storied fabric.

While it does spark fears of diluting the intensity of competition, as has been the case with the expanded UEFA Champions League, the charm of underdogs adds a seasoning of unpredictability.

Curacao and Cabo Verde, whose

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